

A CLOSER LOOK Skin to skin

Skin to skin is when you place your naked baby (except for her diaper) directly onto your bare chest. Take time to relax in each others' quiet company—time spent doing absolutely nothing other than being together is valuable bonding time, especially if you choose to do it skin to skin. Pull a sheet over you both to keep snug. Allow yourself to enjoy your baby's physical presence: her warm weight on your chest, her small hand curling around your finger, and her soft head against your cheek.

Skin-to-skin contact This provides benefits immediately after birth. Direct contact can help you and your baby feel close throughout the first hours of her life. It's a perfect transition from the warmth and protection of your uterus to the coziness of your body.

Getting acquainted The more time you spend skin to skin the quicker you will get to know each other in the early days and weeks. It's a way of communicating your love for your baby and feeling confident that you can provide for her as you have during your pregnancy.

Calm your baby If your baby is upset or hungry or generally unsettled then holding her against your skin can help her relax. The technique is particularly useful if you are struggling to breast-feed because it gets your baby used to being close to your breast.

